

נה starts with a fundamental and fascinating question which continues up until our very day. The פרשה starts (6:9), אֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ אִישׁ צַדִּיק, Rashi says in these words תּוֹלְדֹתֵיהֶם שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים מַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים. What is Rashi intimating to and what is the חידוש in these apparently simple words? The following answer is brought down by the רבי אלקסנדר in his ספר בית יעקב in the name of the מַפְשִׁיחָא quoted in מעייני של תורה.

When after 120 every person faces the בית דין של מעלה, he'll be asked, "How did you spend your life? What were you busy doing your whole life?" Everyone will answer "I put in all my efforts for my children. I wanted my children to grow up to be a גוטע ייד and a בן תורה." What happens when those children grow up? After they get to the בית דין של מעלה and are asked the same question, they'll give the same answer "I said I spent my whole life raising my children that they should be גוטע יידן and בני תורה." Nobody cares about themselves; they only care about their children, all of their עמל ויגיעה is for their children. So the מַפְשִׁיחָא asks, where is the person himself? Where are you? Where is that בן - אֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ, that all the generations are working so hard to produce? That's why the pasuk says, נֹחַ תּוֹלְדֹת - נֹחַ was himself. He did not exert himself and put all his efforts in only for his children. He saw himself as that child, as that son, as the object of all this effort and יגיעה. He worked to improve himself. He was worthy to be called the son that we're working so hard to make into a עושה מצות. He was working at everything that he could do to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא properly.

That is what Rashi is intimating. תּוֹלְדֹתֵיהֶם שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים מַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים - He was putting in efforts for מעשים טובים. He was doing the efforts to ensure that everything that he did would be לשם שמים and that he would be the result of his efforts. Not only his children, not a bad thing, only the children, but that would be the result of working on himself primarily and the children also.

The מעייני של תורה puts a fascinating vort immediately after the above from the Brisker Rav, R' Yoshe Ber, (I assume it's the הלוי (בית הלוי)). He says, all of my life, I constantly yearned that I should never come to the phrase זכות אבא, [which is a very famous saying in the גמרא, which means that after 120 years, the children are a זכות to their parents because they can continue in their ways.] The Brisker Rav said "I don't want that. I want to be זכות myself. I want to be able to say when I come upstairs and say 'I did what I was sent to do', and that is my ultimate purpose and achievement."

